11+ SPaG

SPaG Notes

The Five Pillars of 11+ Grammar Mastery

WHAT THIS GUIDE COVERS

Five core SPaG topics, each with a reference toolkit and exam-standard practice questions.

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Contents

01 Word Classes (Nouns, Verbs, etc.) 3
02 Punctuation Mastery 5
03 Complex Sentence Structure 7
04 Core Spelling Rules 9
05 Active vs Passive Voice 11

What is SPaG?

Reading Comprehension tests whether a child can understand a text. SPaG tests whether they can command the English language with surgical precision. Every mark in a SPaG paper rewards technical correctness: the right word class, the right punctuation mark, the right spelling.

The 11+ regularly tests concepts that probe all five pillars covered in this booklet. This guide covers each pillar with a worked reference toolkit and exam-standard practice questions with full answer explanations.

> *"The 11+ does not test whether a child can write. It tests whether they can write **correctly.**"*

01 SPaG

Word Classes (Nouns, Verbs, etc.)

5 min read · Topic 1 of 5

SPaG Reference: The Toolkit

Use this technical reference to instantly master 11+ grammar questions.

Nouns (The Architecture)

- ***Proper:*** Specific names requiring capital letters (London, Jupiter).
- ***Common:*** General items (table, dog).
- ***Abstract:*** Invisible concepts and feelings (bravery, time, sorrow).
- ***Collective:*** Groups of things (a pride of lions, a flock of birds).

Verbs (The Engine)

- ***Action:*** Physical or mental movements (run, think, detonate).
- ***Auxiliary:*** Helping verbs showing tense (is, was, has).
- ***Modal:*** Show necessity or possibility (must, should, could).

Adjectives & Adverbs (The Paint)

- ***Adjectives:*** Describe nouns. (The ferocious wolf).
- ***Adverbs:*** Describe verbs, often ending in -ly. (He ran ferociously).

Prepositions (The Map)

- Shows location or time. (Under the bridge, before dawn).

1. THE CHAMELEON WORDS

In the 11+, examiners will forcefully test your ability to classify words using "Chameleon Words". These are words that completely change their grammatical class depending on where they sit in a sentence.

You cannot just memorise a word class; you must analyse the word's job in the sentence.

| The Swap Technique

Look at the word "fast".

- *"The fast runner..." (Adjective: it describes the noun 'runner')*
- *"He ran fast..." (Adverb: it describes the verb 'ran')*
- *"I will fast for a day..." (Verb: the physical action of not eating)*

Always ask yourself: "What is this word doing to its neighbour?"

SPaG Practice

Test your mastery of the advanced SPaG techniques taught in this module.

QUESTION 1 [2 marks]

Q1 *(Level: Easy)* Which word class does 'bravery' belong to?

- A) Common Noun
- B) Proper Noun
- C) Abstract Noun
- D) Collective Noun
- E) Adjective

QUESTION 2 [2 marks]

Q2 *(Level: Medium)* Read this sentence: The pilot smoothly landed the massive aeroplane on the runway. Which word is the adverb?

- A) pilot
- B) smoothly
- C) landed
- D) massive
- E) runway

QUESTION 3 [2 marks]

Q3 *(Level: Hard)* Identify the grammatical role of the word 'light' in this sentence: Please light the fire before it gets freezing cold.

- A) Noun
- B) Verb
- C) Adjective
- D) Adverb
- E) Preposition

QUESTION 4 [2 marks]

Q4 *(Level: Hard)* Which sentence contains a modal verb?

- A) He ran down the street quickly.
- B) She is walking to the distant shop.
- C) They must finish the dangerous mission by dawn.
- D) We have completed the homework already.
- E) I bought a massive new car.

QUESTION 5 [2 marks]

Q5 *(Level: Extreme)* In the phrase a swarm of aggressive wasps, what grammatical class is 'swarm'?

- A) Pronoun
- B) Abstract Noun
- C) Collective Noun
- D) Proper Noun
- E) Plural Noun

02 SPaG

Punctuation Mastery

6 min read · Topic 2 of 5

SPaG Reference: Punctuation Rules

Use this technical reference to instantly master 11+ grammar questions.

Use this cheat sheet to verify punctuation hierarchies in error-correction tests.

The Comma (,)

- Separates items in a list.
- Separates introductory clauses fronted adverbials. (Before dawn, the troops attacked.)
- Marks non-essential extra information (parenthesis).

The Semicolon (;)

- Connects two closely related, independent sentences without using a conjunction.
- Example: The storm tore the roof off; the family huddled in the basement.

The Colon (:)

- Acts as a gateway. Introduces a list, an explanation, or a quotation.
- Example: He only needed one thing for survival: fresh water.

The Apostrophe (')

- ***Contraction:*** Shows missing letters (Can't, Shouldn't).
- ***Possessive:*** Shows absolute ownership (The dog's collar).

1. CONTROLLING THE READER'S MIND

Punctuation is not just grammar; it is the traffic light system of the English language. It dictates the exact speed and structure with which the reader consumes the information.

| The 'Greengrocer's Apostrophe' Trap

Examiners intentionally hunt for students who use apostrophes to make words plural. This is a fatal spelling error.

- *Wrong: "Fresh apple's for sale"*
- *Right: "Fresh apples for sale"*

You only ever deploy an apostrophe to indicate that someone owns something, or to staple two words together (do + not = don't).

| Dashes vs Hyphens

A hyphen connects compound words (mother-in-law, ice-cold). A dash introduces a sudden break in thought or an abrupt dramatic shift at the end of a sentence.

SPaG Practice

Test your mastery of the advanced SPaG techniques taught in this module.

QUESTION 1 [2 marks]

Q1 *(Level: Easy)* Which sentence uses the apostrophe flawlessly?

- A) The dog's are barking loudly.
- B) The girl's coats were left in the hall.
- C) The cat chased its' tail.
- D) The teacher's desk was covered in paper.
- E) Many car's were parked outside.

QUESTION 2 [2 marks]

Q2 *(Level: Medium)* What punctuation mark is missing from the following sentence? To bake the cake you will need flour sugar and eggs.

- A) Semicolon
- B) Comma
- C) Dash
- D) Apostrophe
- E) Question Mark

QUESTION 3 [2 marks]

Q3 *(Level: Hard)* Which punctuation mark best completes this sentence: The general gave a single, devastating order _____ attack.

- A) Semicolon (;)
- B) Comma (,)
- C) Colon (:)
- D) Full Stop (.)
- E) Hyphen (-)

QUESTION 4 [2 marks]

Q4 *(Level: Extreme)* Examine this sentence: The boy grabbed his heavy coat; the wind was howling aggressively outside. Why is the semicolon utilised?

- A) To introduce a list of weather events.
- B) Because the writer forgot the word 'and'.
- C) To connect two closely related independent sentences gracefully.
- D) To show ownership of the heavy coat.
- E) To replace a comma.

QUESTION 5 [2 marks]

Q5 *(Level: Medium)* Select the correctly punctuated sentence containing a fronted adverbial.

- A) Underneath the rickety old bridge a nasty troll waited.
- B) Underneath the rickety old bridge, a nasty troll waited.
- C) Underneath the rickety old bridge; a nasty troll waited.
- D) Underneath, the rickety old bridge a nasty troll waited.
- E) Underneath, the rickety old bridge, a nasty troll waited.

03 SPaG

Complex Sentence Structure

6 min read · Topic 3 of 5

SPaG Reference: Sentence Anatomy

Use this technical reference to instantly master 11+ grammar questions.

Use this technical reference to dissect the 3 primary sentence architectures.

1. Simple Sentence

- One independent clause. Contains one subject and one verb.
- Example: The furious storm arrived.

2. Compound Sentence

- Two independent clauses joined by a coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS: For, And, But, Or, Yet, So).
- Example: The storm arrived, and the lights flickered violently.

3. Complex Sentence

- One independent main clause attached to at least one dependent subordinate clause.
- Example: Because the storm arrived, the lights flickered violently.

1. SUBORDINATE CLAUSES

The 11+ test aggressively assesses your capacity to identify dependent clauses. A subordinate clause contains a subject and a verb, but it cannot stand alone because it begins with a subordinating conjunction (Because, Although, If, When, While).

If it rains is a subordinate clause; it leaves the reader hanging, demanding a main clause to finish the architectural thought (If it rains, we will stay indoors.).

| Fronted Adverbials

A fronted adverbial is simply a word or clause placed at the very front of the sentence to describe the action before it even happens.

- *Time: Before dawn, the birds began to sing.*
- *Place: Under the bridge, a troll waited.*
- *Manner: Without a sound, the cat crept forward.*

The golden rule: You must securely lock a fronted adverbial away using a comma.

SPaG Practice

Test your mastery of the advanced SPaG techniques taught in this module.

QUESTION 1 [2 marks]

Q1 *(Level: Easy)* Identify the simple sentence from the options below.

- A) The heavy wind blew the roof off, and the rain poured inside.
- B) Although she was utterly exhausted, she continued running the marathon.
- C) The terrifying dragon roared aggressively at the approaching knights.
- D) Because it was getting dark, they lit the wooden torches.
- E) He loved eating pizza, but he hated mushrooms.

QUESTION 2 [2 marks]

Q2 *(Level: Medium)* Which connecting word flawlessly creates a compound sentence? The thief ran blindingly fast, _____ the police officer was faster.

- A) because
- B) although
- C) but
- D) since
- E) despite

QUESTION 3 [2 marks]

Q3 *(Level: Hard)* Identify the subordinate clause in this sentence: The old pirate ship sank rapidly to the bottom of the ocean because a cannonball shattered its hull.

- A) The old pirate ship sank rapidly.
- B) to the bottom of the ocean.
- C) because a cannonball shattered its hull.
- D) a cannonball shattered its hull.
- E) The old pirate ship.

QUESTION 4 [2 marks]

Q4 *(Level: Hard)* Which sentence accurately contains a fronted adverbial of Time?

- A) Bravely, the knight drew his heavy iron sword.
- B) Above the clouds, the aeroplane soared smoothly.
- C) During the brutal winter storm, the wolves stayed perfectly hidden.
- D) Quietly, she closed the heavy oak door.
- E) The wolves stayed perfectly hidden during the brilliant storm.

QUESTION 5 [2 marks]

Q5 *(Level: Extreme)* Which option constitutes a fragment (an incomplete sentence)?

- A) Run away.
- B) The massive tree crashed loudly.
- C) Even though the sun was shining brightly in the sky.
- D) He stopped.
- E) Stop it right now.

04 SPaG

Core Spelling Rules

6 min read · Topic 4 of 5

SPaG Reference: The Spelling Vault

Use this technical reference to instantly master 11+ grammar questions.

Use this technical database to avoid common 11+ spelling traps.

1. 'I before E except after C'

- This classic rule applies when the sound is a long /ee/.
- ***Normal:*** Believe, Relief, Retrieve
- ***After C:*** Receive, Ceiling, Deceit
- ***Exceptions:*** Science, Weird, Protein

2. The Double Consonant Rule

- If a word ends in a single vowel and a single consonant, and you are adding a suffix that begins with a vowel, you must double the final consonant.
- ***Run:*** Running (not runing)
- ***Big:*** Biggest (not bigest)

3. Dropping the 'E'

- If a root word ends in a silent 'e' and you add a suffix starting with a vowel, drop the 'e'.
- ***Make:*** Making
- ***Hope:*** Hoped

1. THE LOGIC OF ENGLISH SPELLING

English spelling often seems agonisingly random, but 80% of words follow strict, established patterns. Examiners will heavily target the 20% that break the rules.

| Dealing with 'Y' Endings

When a root word terminates in a consonant followed by a 'y', that 'y' turns into an 'i' when you attach almost any suffix (except -ing).

- *Happy + ness = Happiness*
- *Carry + ed = Carried*
- *Play + ed = Played (The 'y' stays because 'a' is a vowel, not a consonant)*

| Silent Assassins

Watch out for 'silent guests' hiding within root words.

- *The invisible 'k' in Knew or Knight.*
- *The hidden 'w' in Sword or Wrestle.*
- *The trailing 'b' in Comb or Dumb.*

SPaG Practice

Test your mastery of the advanced SPaG techniques taught in this module.

QUESTION 1 [2 marks]

Q1 *(Level: Easy)* Which word is spelled incorrectly?

- A) Belief
- B) Receive
- C) Ceiling
- D) Cheif
- E) Relief

QUESTION 2 [2 marks]

Q2 *(Level: Medium)* Apply the suffix '-ing' to the word stop.

- A) stoping
- B) stoppong

- C) stopping
- D) stoping
- E) stopped

QUESTION 3 [2 marks]

Q3 *(Level: Medium)* What is the correct spelling when you add '-ed' to the word worry?

- A) worryed
- B) worriyed
- C) worried
- D) worryd
- E) worred

QUESTION 4 [2 marks]

Q4 *(Level: Hard)* Which option completely disobeys the 'I before E' rule?

- A) Piece
- B) Field
- C) Weird
- D) Shield
- E) Grief

QUESTION 5 [2 marks]

Q5 *(Level: Extreme)* Examine the word argue. What happens when you aggressively apply the suffix '-ment'?

- A) The word becomes arguement.
- B) The 'e' is traditionally dropped: argument.
- C) You double the 'u': arguument.
- D) The 'u' vanishes: argment.
- E) It splits into two words: argue ment.

05 SPaG

Active vs Passive Voice

6 min read · Topic 5 of 5

SPaG Reference: The Voice Switch

Use this technical reference to instantly master 11+ grammar questions.

Use this technical module to deeply understand how to shift narrative focus by swapping sentence voices.

The Active Voice (Direct & Energetic)

- The Subject aggressively performs the action on the Object.
- ***Example:*** The vicious dragon [Subject] guarded [Verb] the gold [Object].
- ***Purpose:*** Used for clear, fast-paced action storytelling.

The Passive Voice (Formal & Objective)

- The Object is moved to the front and the action happens to it.
- ***Example:*** The gold [front] was guarded [Verb] by the vicious dragon.
- ***Purpose:*** Used for formal reporting, scientific facts, or mysterious evasion.

1. THE SUBJECT-OBJECT FLIP

Switching voice is essentially just swapping the person doing the action with the thing receiving the action.

If the sentence is "The chef baked the cake":

- *1. Locate the Object (the cake)*
- *2. Move it to the front of the sentence.*
- *3. Add a helping verb ('was')*
- *4. Result: "The cake was baked by the chef."*

| Why Use the Passive Voice?

Examiners test passive voice to see if you understand tone. Passive voice is brilliant for hiding blame. If a child shatters a window, instead of actively admitting 'I shattered the window', they can passively claim 'The window was shattered.' It completely deletes the actor from the crime!

SPaG Practice

Test your mastery of the advanced SPaG techniques taught in this module.

QUESTION 1 [2 marks]

Q1 *(Level: Easy)* Identify the sentence written in the Active Voice.

- A) The expensive vase was smashed by the cat.
- B) The heavy car was driven rapidly.
- C) The cat smashed the expensive vase.
- D) The homework was completed by the student.
- E) The song was enthusiastically sung by the choir.

QUESTION 2 [2 marks]

Q2 *(Level: Medium)* Change this active sentence into the passive voice: The police officer chased the robber down the dark street.

- A) The robber chased the police officer down the dark street.
- B) The robber was chased by the police officer down the dark street.
- C) The police officer was chasing the robber.
- D) The dark street was guarded by the police officer.
- E) The officer chased the running robber away.

QUESTION 3 [2 marks]

Q3 *(Level: Hard)* Which of these sentences is in the Passive Voice but completely hides who did the action?

- A) The old bridge was built by the Roman army.
- B) The furious headteacher cancelled the exam.
- C) The secret documents were completely destroyed in the fire.
- D) A wild bear attacked the campsite.
- E) The red team won the chaotic match.

QUESTION 4 [2 marks]

Q4 *(Level: Hard)* Look at this sentence: The magnificent sandcastle was thoroughly crushed by the incoming tide. Who or what is the 'Actor' doing the action?

- A) The magnificent sandcastle
- B) The incoming tide
- C) The person who built it
- D) The heavy crushing
- E) The ocean fish

QUESTION 5 [2 marks]

Q5 *(Level: Extreme)* When writing a formal scientific lab report, why should a student primarily use the Passive Voice?

- A) Because it guarantees the sentences are shorter and heavily punched in.
- B) Because science words are inherently difficult to spell actively.
- C) To decisively focus all attention on the experiment and results, rather than the person performing the test.
- D) To make the report sound incredibly emotional and fictional.
- E) Because the active voice is strictly forbidden in schools.

Answers and Explanations

Complete answers with full explanations for every practice question.

Section 01: Word Classes

Q1. *(Level: Easy)* **Answer: C) Abstract Noun**

'Bravery' is an invisible feeling or concept that you cannot touch or see. Abstract nouns represent emotions, ideas, and states. 'Common Noun' is a classic distractor as it is the most familiar category to students.

Q2. *(Level: Medium)* **Answer: B) smoothly**

An adverb modifies a verb. 'Smoothly' describes how the pilot landed the plane and follows the classic -ly pattern. 'Massive' is an adjective (it describes the noun 'aeroplane'), which is the primary distractor here.

Q3. *(Level: Hard)* **Answer: B) Verb**

In this sentence, 'light' is performing a physical action and is what the subject is being told to do. This is a classic Chameleon Word: 'light' can be an adjective (a light bag) or a noun (the light was on), but here its job is that of a verb.

Q4. *(Level: Hard)* **Answer: C) They must finish the dangerous mission by dawn.**

'Must' is a modal verb that expresses necessity or obligation. Options A and B use action and auxiliary verbs respectively. Option D uses 'have completed' (auxiliary + past participle). Option E has no modal verb at all.

Q5. *(Level: Extreme)* **Answer: C) Collective Noun**

A 'swarm' is the specific collective noun for a group of wasps or bees. It names the group as a single unit. Students often confuse this with 'Plural Noun' (E), but plural nouns simply add -s, whereas collective nouns are unique vocabulary items with precise meanings.

Section 02: Punctuation Mastery

Q1. *(Level: Easy)* **Answer: B) The girl's coats were left in the hall.**

The apostrophe in 'girl's' correctly shows possession: the coats belonging to the girl. Option A incorrectly uses an apostrophe to pluralise 'dogs'. Option C uses 'its'' incorrectly; the possessive 'its' never takes an apostrophe. Option E makes the same pluralisation error.

Q2. *(Level: Medium)* **Answer: B) Comma**

The sentence lists three ingredients: flour, sugar, and eggs. A comma is required to separate items in a list. No other punctuation mark performs this list-separating function in standard grammar.

Q3. *(Level: Hard)* **Answer: C) Colon (:)**

A colon acts as a gateway: it introduces what follows directly from what precedes it. Here, 'attack' is the specific explanation of what the 'single devastating order' was. A semicolon joins two equal, independent clauses and would not work here.

Q4. *(Level: Extreme)* **Answer: C) To connect two closely related independent sentences gracefully.**

The sentence has two complete ideas: the boy grabbed his coat, and the wind was howling. These two events are directly linked in cause and atmosphere, making the semicolon the perfect grammatical bridge between them.

Q5. *(Level: Medium)* **Answer: B) Underneath the rickety old bridge, a nasty troll waited.**

This fronted adverbial ('Underneath the rickety old bridge') tells the reader where the action takes place before stating the action. The golden rule is that a fronted adverbial must always be followed immediately by a comma.

Section 03: Complex Sentence Structure

Q1. *(Level: Easy)* **Answer: C) The terrifying dragon roared aggressively at the approaching knights.**

This sentence has exactly one subject (dragon) and one verb (roared). It contains no conjunctions and no subordinate clauses. Option A is compound (uses 'and'). Options B and D are complex (begin with subordinating conjunctions).

Q2. *(Level: Medium)* **Answer: C) but**

The word 'but' is a coordinating conjunction (the 'B' in FANBOYS). It joins two independent clauses of equal grammatical weight. 'Because', 'although', 'since', and 'despite' are all subordinating conjunctions that would create a complex sentence, not a compound one.

Q3. *(Level: Hard)* **Answer: C) because a cannonball shattered its hull.**

A subordinate clause begins with a subordinating conjunction and cannot stand alone. 'Because a cannonball shattered its hull' starts with 'because', making it dependent. If you read it alone, it feels unfinished: that is the test.

Q4. *(Level: Hard)* **Answer: C) During the brutal winter storm, the wolves stayed perfectly hidden.**

'During the brutal winter storm' is a fronted adverbial of time telling us when. It is placed at the front and followed by a comma. Option A ('Bravely') is a fronted adverbial of manner, not time.

Q5. *(Level: Extreme)* **Answer: C) Even though the sun was shining brightly in the sky.**

This is a subordinate clause with no main clause attached. It begins with 'Even though' (a subordinating conjunction), making it permanently dependent. It cannot stand alone as a complete thought, making it a fragment by definition.

Section 04: Core Spelling Rules

Q1. *(Level: Easy)* **Answer: D) Cheif**

The correct spelling is 'Chief'. This follows the 'I before E' pattern (ch-ie-f). The misspelling 'Cheif' reverses the 'ie' to 'ei', which is incorrect when the sound is a long /ee/ and there is no preceding 'c'.

Q2. *(Level: Medium)* **Answer: C) stopping**

'Stop' ends in a single vowel (o) followed by a single consonant (p). When adding a vowel suffix like '-ing', you must double the final consonant: stopping. 'Stoping' fails to double the consonant. This is the Double Consonant Rule in action.

Q3. *(Level: Medium)* **Answer: C) worried**

'Curry' ends in a consonant (r) followed by 'y'. When adding '-ed', the 'y' changes to 'i' following the Y-to-I rule. The result is 'worr-i-ed' = worried. 'Worryed' incorrectly keeps the 'y' before adding the suffix.

Q4. *(Level: Hard)* **Answer: C) Weird**

'Weird' is the classic exception to the 'I before E' rule: it contains 'ei' despite not following a 'c', and it does not make a long /ee/ sound. Examiners use this word specifically to test whether students know the rule's exceptions.

Q5. *(Level: Extreme)* **Answer: B) The 'e' is traditionally dropped: argument.**

'Argue' ends in a silent 'e'. When you add the suffix '-ment', which begins with a consonant, you must drop the silent 'e'. The correct form is 'argument', not 'arguement', which is one of the most common spelling errors in the 11+.

Section 05: Active vs Passive Voice

Q1. *(Level: Easy)* **Answer: C) The cat smashed the expensive vase.**

In the active voice, the Subject (the cat) performs the action (smashed) directly on the Object (the vase). Options A, B, D, and E all use 'was + past participle', which is the classic passive construction signature.

Q2. *(Level: Medium)* **Answer: B) The robber was chased by the police officer down the dark street.**

To convert to passive: move the Object (the robber) to the front, add the auxiliary 'was', change the verb to its past participle (chased), and add 'by' before the original subject. Option A merely reverses the subject and object without changing the voice.

Q3. *(Level: Hard)* **Answer: C) The secret documents were completely destroyed in the fire.**

This sentence is passive (were destroyed) but the 'by' phrase has been deliberately omitted. We do not know who destroyed them: the actor is hidden. This is the grammatical technique of passive evasion. All other options either use active voice or retain the subject.

Q4. *(Level: Hard)* **Answer: B) The incoming tide**

In a passive sentence, the true 'Actor' is found after the word 'by'. Here, 'by the incoming tide' reveals the tide as the force doing the crushing. The sandcastle is the grammatical subject but the passive recipient of the action.

Q5. *(Level: Extreme)* **Answer: C) To decisively focus all attention on the experiment and results, rather than the person performing the test.**

Scientific writing uses the passive voice to maintain objectivity and direct the reader's focus to the findings, not the researcher. 'The solution was heated' is more authoritative than 'I heated the solution'. Options A, B, D, and E are all factually incorrect.